Structure: Putting It All Together

Marc Alexander · Week 7

1 The Structure of Modern English

- **From *nothing* to words:** Take words, group them into similar families, give them names.
- **From words to phrases:** Combine words, acting as headwords or modifiers, into phrases. Group phrases into similar families, and give them names.
- **From phrases to clauses:** Say what these phrases are doing in relation to each other and group them.
- **From clauses to sentences:** Combine clauses into complex or compound sentences.
- **Look out:** for strangenesses and embedding!

2 How to Parse – 1

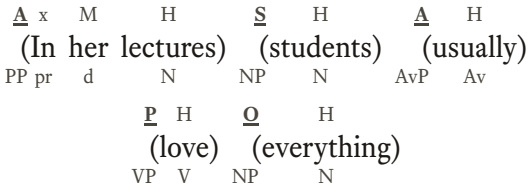
- Do the easy parts of speech first
  - For example, obvious nouns and verbs, adverbs ending in -ly, prepositions like "to" and "in", determiners like "the" and "a"...
- Count the main verbs to work out how many clauses
- Identify any phrases you can
  - For example, from a preposition to a noun is a noun phrase, a verb on its own with no auxiliaries is a verb phrase...
- Identify modifiers and headwords (and those which are neither)
  - You should have a clue from the types of phrases you identified before

3 How to Parse – 2

- Go back and see if you can identify anything else
  - Try the substitution and coordination tests
- Do this until you have the parts of speech and phrases done
- Identify clause elements
  - For example, a VP is always the Predicator, a highly mobile unit (which adds to the meaning of the verb phrase) is an Adverbial, AvPs and PPs are Adverbials, AjPs are Complements, and then test for Subject and Object agreement
- Finally, identify clauses based on how many predicators you found

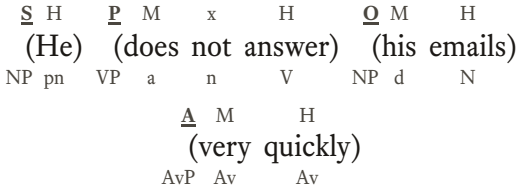
4 Sentence 1

> In her lectures, students usually love everything.



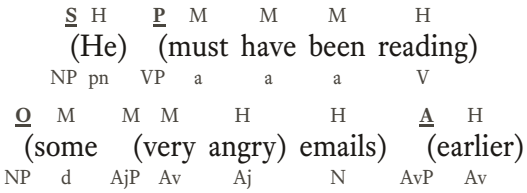
5 Sentence 2

> He does not answer his emails very quickly.



6 Sentence 3

> He must have been reading some very angry emails earlier.



7 Sentence 4

> Actually, he works at home very rarely these days.

